

Q When might I be offered the different ultrasounds and tests?

The table below sets out the expected pattern of ultrasounds and tests during the course of your pregnancy. Some of these are offered to all pregnant women, others are for those in certain situations.

TIME LINE OF TESTS AND ULTRASOUNDS

WEEKS PREGNANT	TEST/ULTRASOUND	WHAT IS IT FOR?
4-5	Ultrasound if family history of twins	Check growth and heartbeats
8-14 *	The first ultrasound	Measure growth and estimates delivery date
11-14 *	Nuchal translucency test	Assesses risk of abnormalities
10-20	Blood tests	Assess risk of abnormalities
10-15	Chorionic villus sampling (CVS)	Diagnostic test for abnormalities
18-20	Fetal anatomy scan (ultrasound)	Diagnostic test for abnormalities
from 14	Amniocentesis	Diagnostic test for abnormalities
22-23	Repeat of anatomy scan	Take detailed fetal measurements
from 18-24	Cordocentesis	Diagnostic test for abnormalities
28-40	ultrasound or ultrasounds	Check growth and development

* The nuchal translucency test may be combined with the first ultrasound if the latter is done around 11 to 14 weeks.



Q I've never had an ultrasound before. What does it involve?

During an abdominal ultrasound appointment, you will be asked to lie down on a raised bed.

The room will be dark so that the images show up clearly on the screen—sort of like dimming the lights at the movies. The sonographer will apply gel to your stomach and then move a handheld scanner over your abdomen. Don't worry if he or she has to press hard from time to time to get the right position. A sonographer is a medical professional who may also be a radiographer (a person who takes X-rays), with training in skeletal anatomy, who likely specializes in prenatal ultrasound. He or she will make assessments of your baby's health according to certain statistics (the length of the baby's spine and femur, head circumference, abdominal circumference etc.) and what observations he or she can make from the images on the screen. When you go to the appointment for your 20-week ultrasound, a sonographer will be the person who's examining your baby's anatomy to make sure that all of the body parts look normal and healthy. This is the appointment when it may be possible for you and your partner to finally learn the sex of your baby on the way, if that's of interest to you. If you don't want to know the gender before your baby is born, be sure to tell the sonographer at the start of your ultrasound appointment, well before he or she starts describing what's in view onscreen!

Q Is an ultrasound safe for my baby? Are there any risks?

As far as it's possible to tell, it is perfectly safe for you and your baby. The ultrasound is performed using a handheld device that uses sound waves to build a picture of your baby.

Unlike X-rays (which use radio waves), sound waves have no link to increased risk of childhood cancer or congenital abnormality in babies. The "beams" of sound penetrate your amniotic fluid and bounce off your baby's tiny body to create a moving image. Some people worry that sound waves will raise your core temperature, but actually the temperature rise from using an ultrasound is usually no more than 1.8°F (1°C), which is well below any level for concern.